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Changes in Nubian wedding ceremonials

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LAST STAGE: POST WEDDING FESTIVITIES • *Ṣabāhiyya*.

LAST STAGE: POST WEDDING FESTIVITIES

Ṣabāhiyya.

The term *ṣabāhiyya* denotes the morning after the wedding, and since the marriage was generally consummated on that day, the activities of *ṣabāhiyya* were considered an especially important part of the wedding celebration. To begin the *ṣabāhiyya*, both the bride and the groom went separately to the Nile early in the morning in the company of friends and relatives who had spent the night with them. Again offerings were made to the angels of the river, who would then protect the fertility of the couple. As the groom returned from the river, he quietly entered the bride's quarters accompanied by the midwife and the *dewinsha*, whose role it was to serve the married couple for seven days after the wedding.

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The bride, still veiled, sat on a special mat. Traditionally, she would under no circumstances talk to the groom until he had paid her a sum of money (varying from sixty piasters to two pounds). The Nubians referred to this ritual, and to the money itself, as *agbanyed* (which in the Mahas dialect means "the opening of the mouth"). After a period of feigning reluctance, which might last as long as half an hour or more, she finally accepted the money, and spoke to her groom. This signal permitted physical consummation to proceed, but due to the fashion in which Nubian girls were infibulated (the "Pharaonic way"), it was usually necessary for the midwife to perform an operation to open the vagina. Sometimes this was so frightening and painful

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that defloration could not be accomplished on this day and had to be attempted again later. Usually there was little difficulty, however, and the bridal couple were then left alone for their first intercourse.

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While the "opening of the mouth" ceremony was going on, much joking and loud laughter issued from both the groups of women and men. Sometimes, peepholes had been made into the bridal quarters so that watchers could report to the group how long the girl was able to bargain and thus delay consummation. Giving in too quickly was regarded as evidence of undue interest in sex, which did not bode well for the future. It is said that in days gone by, consummation sometimes did not take place until the *kolod*, seven days after the wedding day.

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